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A Discussion on Discovery School
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The Discovery School: <http://school.discovery.com/teachingtools/teachingtools.html>

DiscoverySchool.com, or rather, Discovery Education, has some good teaching materials available online that provide resources and services to teachers, parents, and students across all subjects, including an array of powerful tools that help you create your own materials—lesson planners, teacher’s store, teaching tools, and video on demand.

DiscoverySchool.com, or rather, Discovery Education, has some good teaching materials available online, including lesson planners, a teacher’s store, teaching tools, video-on-demand, and more. One of the most powerful features of Discoveryschool.com is the ability to create your own materials.

One of the services I liked is education and professional development. This service provides ongoing training and professional development for teachers, professional development staff, students, and educators. In addition, discoverschools.com offers many useful resources (e.g., links). I liked Kathy Schrock’s Guide for Educators and especially her selection of search engines—Google, AltaVista, and so on.

I am not sure if these online goods and services qualified as mindtools. Puzzle makers, lesson planners, quiz centers, worksheet generators, clip art galleries, and so on are good teaching materials. Even though discoverschool.com has a wealth of knowledge (or resources) available online, including videos and CD-ROMs, I have to classify these as educational resources/supplemental materials. However, DiscoverSchool.com does offer some powerful tools in making learning fun.

One definition of mindtools is defined as knowledge representation tools that use computer application programs such as databases, semantic networks (computer concept maps), spreadsheets, expert systems, and system modeling tools, micro-worlds, intentional information search engines, visualization tools, multimedia publishing tools, live conversation environments, and computer conferences to engage learners in critical thinking.

Criteria for evaluating mindtools include computer-based, available applications, affordability, knowledge construction, generalizability, critical thinking, transferable learning, simplicity, powerful formalism, and ease of learning.

Here is a list of services:

Puzzle maker – generate your own education crossword puzzles, math squares, word search, and more.

Lesson Planner – create and store your customized lesson plans

Quiz Center –quiz-making tool online

Worksheet Generator – create custom worksheets for almost any subject.

Clip Art Gallery – Choose from hundreds of original clip art pieces to dress up your next handout.

Teacher Store – all subjects and professional development

Homework Helpers – study tools, fun & games, learning adventures

Discoverschool.com has a few broken links: “About Us”, “Feedback”, “PRIVACY POLICY”, “Viewing & Printing Our Site”, and “Copyright”. These links do not work (i.e., 404).

I am trying to find information about who or what sponsors DiscoverSchool.com, and I am not at all surprised that DiscoverSchool.com is part of Discovery.com. I guess part of the funding comes from state and federal education funds. Another source, though, is sponsor website links and the sale of lesson plans, CD-ROMs, and videos.

Two of my favorite websites include <http://www.readinga-z.com> and <http://www.edhelper.com>. These two Websites offer similar resources as discoveryschool.com geared toward grades K-12.